

Inspection of Liverpool local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 11 May to 22 May 2026

Lead inspector: Teresa Godfrey, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Requires improvement to be good

Services for children and families in Liverpool have significantly improved since the inspection in 2023, when overall effectiveness was judged to be inadequate. Most children now receive services that are making a positive difference to their lives. The areas for improvement and widespread failures identified during the inspection in 2023 have been addressed with rigor and pace, resulting in tangible improvements across all practice areas. Although there are some areas where the quality of practice is variable, significant progress has been achieved, particularly in relation to developing a strong workforce culture, introducing a new model of practice, reducing practitioners' caseloads and recognising and responding to the risk of harm.

Following the inspection in 2023, changes across the senior leadership team in children's services and the council included appointments of a new chief executive, leader of the council, director of children's services (DCS) and lead member. The new senior leadership team understood and accepted that significant change was needed and did not delay in implementing plans, which were sharply focused on improving the quality of practice across children's social care. Improvement plans were supported by significant financial investment to increase workforce capacity and reduce the reliance on agency teams.

The DCS and her senior leadership team have an informed understanding of the strengths and areas for development through accurate self-evaluation and through the oversight of an effective improvement board. There are still some areas where the quality of practice is inconsistent, and leaders know that there is more to do to ensure that all vulnerable children and young people are receiving the support they need. This includes the response to homeless children, oversight of permanence planning, and the quality and impact of pathway plans for care leavers.

What needs to improve?¹

- The response to children who present as homeless and to those living in private fostering arrangements. (Outcome 3, national framework)
- The consistent oversight and use of performance management tools that support decision-making for children in care. (Outcome 4, national framework)
- The quality of pathway plans for care leavers. (Outcome 4, national framework)
- The response to care leavers who are not in employment, education and training. (Outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and families in Liverpool have access to a wide range of timely and effective early help services. Experienced family support workers based in family hubs and children's centres support them to receive help that is proportionate to their needs.
2. Family help assessments are holistic, child centred and well written. Children benefit from sensitive direct work, which improves their experiences. When circumstances change for children, decisions to step up to statutory services or step down to universal services are appropriate, and as a result, most children receive the right help at the right time.
3. Most contacts to the children's advice and support service (CASS) are made promptly by partners. For some children, the quality of contacts is variable. Referrers do not routinely consider whether a child's circumstances merit social care involvement and do not clearly identify concerns. For a small number of children, this results in a short delay between a contact being received and social work triage taking place in the multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH). Leaders appropriately challenge partners on the quality of their referrals and are in the

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

process of implementing a new portal with the aim of improving the quality of contacts from the wider partnership.

4. There is management oversight of all contacts to the CASS and managers prioritise in line with presenting need and risk. Where there are immediate safeguarding concerns, these are appropriately recognised, prioritised and promptly responded to. When need is less urgent, allocation is sometimes delayed. This means that, for a small number of children, they do not receive the support they need at the earliest opportunity.
5. Social workers in the MASH are child focused and consider children's social care history and partner agency information when making their recommendations. Social workers identify and understand the impact of domestic abuse on children. When risks are linked to exploitation, or children and young people are reported missing, there is a timely and appropriate response. Next steps are recommended in line with assessed risk, and this means that children receive help that is proportionate to their needs.
6. Once a decision has been made in the MASH that the threshold is met for statutory children's services involvement, there is no delay in children progressing for assessment by a social worker.
7. The emergency duty team takes action to ensure that children are protected until the next working day. Robust handover arrangements with daytime services ensure that children's holistic needs are assessed.
8. Strategy meetings for the majority of children are timely and are well attended by partner agencies. Presenting risks, including historical and partner agency information, are well considered, and this results in effective multi-agency planning. Strategy meetings are well recorded and provide a clear rationale for how decisions have been reached. Actions are appropriate for most children, and these include steps to ensure that children are protected from risk of harm.
9. Children are seen promptly and immediate safety plans are put in place where needed. Safety plans are clear and explicit. However, for a small number of children, the quality of the plans is variable and there is an overoptimistic reliance on the capacity of parents to protect effectively.
10. Child protection enquiries are timely and build on the actions identified in strategy meetings. Social workers carry out direct work with children to develop trust and to help them understand their experiences. Children's wishes and feelings are captured effectively and inform assessments and plans. Next steps, including decisions to progress to initial child protection conferences, are appropriate.
11. The quality of assessments is strong, which is a significant improvement since the last inspection. Assessments are thorough and contain a comprehensive and proportionate consideration of family history and emerging risks. They are timely

and informed by research, partner agency contributions and children's lived experiences. Social workers seek to understand children's ethnicity, identity and diversity and, for most children, this is well reflected in their assessment. Support and intervention take place during assessments, and this means that families do not wait for the help that they need.

12. Child protection conferences, core groups and child in need reviews take place regularly with strong partnership attendance. Children, including disabled children, benefit from well-written assessments and plans that are specific to their individual needs and include contingency planning. Child protection chairs and independent reviewing officers (IROs) provide a strong grip and oversight of children's circumstances and plans. Family group conferences are held promptly. For many children, these conferences result in their family network providing impactful support, which improves children's experiences.
13. Services for disabled children have significantly improved since the last inspection. Specialist workers have a strong understanding of the complex needs of disabled children, including when they need protection. They visit children regularly and use appropriate tools to ensure that they capture children's views and wishes, and these are reflected in assessments and plans.
14. When children are experiencing neglect, skilled practitioners complete strong, evaluative assessments, underpinned by research. These assessments result in plans which ensure that parents are supported to understand what needs to change and how to achieve it. Senior leaders have recently introduced new neglect tools to support practitioners, although it was too soon to see the impact of this.
15. Social workers recognise and respond effectively to risks linked to exploitation. Specialist workers build relationships with children and undertake effective direct work, which helps to reduce risk. This focused work is not always reflected in, or coordinated through, children's written plans. When children go missing from home, they benefit from detailed return home interviews that appropriately explore push-and-pull factors.
16. For children in need and those subject to child protection plans, their social workers visit them in line with their assessed need. Children are visited often enough for social workers to build trusting relationships with them. Visits have purpose and they link to children's plans. For the majority of children, this results in their plans progressing and their experiences improving.
17. When children are not being effectively safeguarded by a child protection plan and concerns escalate, they are appropriately considered at legal gateway meetings. The quality of information presented at legal gateway meetings is usually strong, resulting in timely decision-making.

18. There is a strong emphasis on children being supported to remain in their family networks when this is safe and appropriate. For children in the pre-proceedings phase of the Public Law Outline, connected carer assessments are considered promptly.
19. The quality of pre-proceedings letters is variable. Not all letters succinctly and clearly set out for parents what the concerns are and what they must do to address them. Leaders recognised this and took appropriate action during the inspection to improve this area of practice. For some children, a range of services bespoke to their needs, including the family drug and alcohol court (FDAC) team, are successfully improving their circumstances and diverting them from court.
20. Oversight of children in pre-proceedings has been strengthened since the last inspection and there is now robust tracking of their circumstances. This means that, when plans of support do not improve outcomes, children do not experience delay before appropriate action is taken.
21. The response to children who present as homeless is inconsistent. When joint assessments with housing are completed, these appropriately identify support and accommodation needs. However, not all children who present as homeless receive a timely response or are made aware of their rights and entitlements.
22. Children living in private fostering arrangements are visited regularly. The quality of the assessments of their circumstances is variable and, for some children, essential statutory checks are not completed in a timely way. Leaders are appropriately aware that there is more to do to strengthen oversight and practice to ensure that these children are living in safe and appropriate homes.
23. The local authority designated officers provide a prompt response when there are allegations made against adults working with children.
24. Children and young people who are carers are well supported in Liverpool. Holistic and child-centred assessments result in support plans that are carefully tailored to their needs.
25. There is a strong and conscientious level of accountability and oversight of children who are educated at home and for those missing education at strategic and operational levels. Workers are tenacious in making sure that children receive the support they need. This includes a vigilant level of focus on safeguarding concerns.
26. When families are in crisis, children benefit from experienced, skilled and caring family support workers within the dedicated edge of care team, who provide trauma-informed direct work. This is supporting children to remain safely living at home.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

27. There is effective oversight and scrutiny of decisions to bring children into care. Children enter into the care of the local authority when it is necessary to ensure that they are safeguarded. Children are supported to remain in the care of their family members, including through kinship arrangements, when it is safe for them to do so.
28. Children in care are helped to maintain relationships with those people who are important to them, including brothers, sisters, wider family and previous carers. Social workers and carers flexibly and proactively promote family time. The emotional impact of seeing family members is carefully considered, and family time arrangements are assessed and adapted in line with need and risk. When arrangements are changed or are not in their best interests, children are helped to understand the reasons for this.
29. Children, including disabled children in care, are visited at a frequency that matches their level of need. Some children have experienced multiple changes of social worker, but most are now benefiting from stable and positive relationships with social workers who take time to get to know them and understand their experiences. Records of social workers' visits to children vary in detail and quality. Stronger recordings capture the warmth and humour in social workers' relationships with children.
30. Social workers carry out effective direct work, which supports children to have a good understanding of their lived experience. For a small number of children, the quality of direct work is variable and not started at the earliest opportunity.
31. Children in care have their needs reassessed at least annually. Assessments are detailed and thoughtfully explore children's experiences, wellbeing, culture, identity, who is important to them, and how their needs are being met. Assessments inform care planning and most children benefit from plans that are clear, comprehensive, written directly to and co-produced with them.
32. Children are actively contributing to their plans and reviews and can access advocacy services to support them with this. Reviews for children in care are regular and well attended. Care planning meetings held between reviews provide tight scrutiny and oversight of the progress of most children's care plans. Plans are sharply focused on supporting children to achieve permanence and stability.
33. Children benefit from IROs who take time to get to know them and to seek their views. IRO records are sensitive and child friendly. They demonstrate warmth, interest and a strong professional investment in children's progress. IROs add scrutiny through mid-point reviews and hold professionals to account effectively, reducing drift for some children.

34. Since the last inspection, permanence planning for children has improved. Oversight arrangements have been strengthened, and many children have achieved legal permanence. Permanence for children is routinely reviewed and extended family options are considered so children can live with those family members who know them best.
35. Viability assessments of connected carers are now thorough and promptly completed. A revised special guardianship offer is appropriately supporting some kinship carers to pursue special guardianship orders. Many children on care orders living at home with their parents have had their orders revoked and unnecessary statutory intervention in their lives has ended. Nevertheless, a small number of children have experienced delays in achieving permanence. Senior leaders are rightly aware that there is more to do to ensure that there is effective oversight of, and planning for, all children in care.
36. Skilled and experienced social workers ensure that most children are supported to live in stable and suitable homes, where their carers understand and meet their needs. Social workers, carers and birth families work together to ensure that children's cultural, religious and unique identity needs are understood and supported in their homes. For disabled children, their unique needs are understood and addressed comprehensively by multi-agency networks.
37. When placements are fragile, stability meetings are held and support is put in place. Many children thrive in well-matched, long-term foster families and have a strong sense of their identity and long-term security. As they get older, most children are supported to live in staying-put arrangements where possible. Practitioners carefully consider what support and intervention is required to support children to live independently.
38. Children are supported to enjoy hobbies and interests. Reviews explicitly capture what children are good at and how they should be encouraged to pursue these activities.
39. Social workers take an active interest in children's educational attainment and experiences. Effective work with education providers and the virtual school is supporting children to achieve their goals and aspirations. Most children are supported to understand their health histories and have their physical, emotional and mental health needs met. Schools, foster carers and the virtual school are well sighted on children's emotional difficulties in school and the impact this can have on their learning.
40. Children who are at risk from harm outside the family, or who go missing, receive an effective response. Unaccompanied children and young people are well supported by practitioners who are alert and sensitive to their experiences and the trauma they have suffered.

41. A very small number of children live in unregistered children's homes for short periods. Unregistered homes are only used when all other options have been exhausted. Arrangements are subject to robust oversight and frequent visits to ensure children's safety and wellbeing until a more suitable placement is identified.
42. Challenges to sufficiency impact on the choice of placements and the quality of some children's experiences. There is strong oversight of children's care arrangements. They are visited in line with need, and they continue to enjoy family time. For some children, a lack of placement choice is the determining factor in them living out of area or being unable to live with their brothers and sisters. A small number of young children who have experienced placement breakdown are living in children's homes and are receiving support while suitable alternative family settings are identified. Leaders appropriately recognise this issue and continue to implement plans to improve local sufficiency, which are beginning to have an impact.
43. Most children leave care in circumstances that are appropriate and in their best interests. Effective planning, assessment and support results in children returning to their family networks in a timely way.
44. Creative recruitment strategies and the promotion of flexible fostering pathways have resulted in an increase of foster carers in Liverpool. Assessments of prospective foster carers are thorough, and carers receive regular child-centred support and supervision from their social workers. Annual reviews are timely, comprehensive and valued by carers. The introduction of the first constellation of foster carers in Liverpool is providing valuable support to carers and children. Senior leaders have set ambitious targets to ensure that all foster carers have the training required to provide good-quality care.
45. The regional adoption agency (Adoption in Merseyside) provides recruitment, assessment and support services to adopters. The local authority's dedicated adoption service is a strength. Social workers who specialise in adoption work are experienced and skilful. Direct work in this part of the service is supporting children to understand their journey to adoption.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: requires improvement to be good

46. Since the last inspection, there has been an improvement in the quality of service provided to care leavers from a very low base. There has been significant investment in the service, and the number of personal advisers (PAs) has been tripled, increasing capacity, reducing workloads and improving the response to young people. Nevertheless, there is more to do to ensure that all children as they leave care benefit from timely transition planning, and that care leavers receive a consistent service that is responsive to and meets their needs.

47. Most children in care aged 16 and 17 get to know their PA prior to their 18th birthdays. Pathway plans completed by social workers reference what needs to be in place and what support children will need as they transition to adulthood.
48. Most children are helped to understand what accommodation options are available to them before they turn 18. Many children are able to remain in their existing settings when this is in their best interests, such as shared lives or staying put with their foster carers.
49. PAs demonstrate a sense of empathy and care for young people. They understand young people's journeys through care and know them well. The young people who spoke to inspectors were very positive about the support and care provided by their PAs. Young people are seen regularly by their PAs and visits are increased during times of greater risk and need. PAs praise and celebrate young people's achievements. Young people's case records do not fully reflect the positive relationships or level of support being provided.
50. The service to care leavers once they turn 21 has been significantly improved since the last inspection. Young people now routinely receive support beyond 21. When decisions are made to end support, this is done in consultation with young people. When young people reach out and request support after they turn 21, this is usually promptly provided. During this inspection, immediate action was taken to improve the annual keeping-in-touch letters, which did not sufficiently encourage young people to get in touch, should they require support.
51. The quality of pathway plans completed by PAs is variable. Many plans are not comprehensive and do not sufficiently support young people to progress towards important goals.
52. Too many care leavers in Liverpool are not in employment, education or training. Many pathway plans are not specific enough in addressing this issue. When young people live outside the city, they do not always receive the same support to secure education, employment or training provided to care leavers in Liverpool.
53. Young people are registered with GPs and dentists, and they are supported to access universal services. Young people are encouraged to seek support for their emotional wellbeing through their GPs, and PAs make appropriate referrals to support young people's mental and emotional health. Some young people find the complicated landscape of support services difficult to navigate and some wait too long to receive the support they need. Senior managers are aware of this and are undertaking purposeful work with health partners in relation to this.
54. Care leavers who are parents have their individual needs met well. PAs support care leavers' specific needs and demonstrate an interest and care in their children's welfare and progress.

55. Former unaccompanied children who become care leavers receive a high level of support, including for their practical needs and emotional wellbeing. Careful consideration is given to ensure that they can access local amenities and networks in line with their religious, cultural and identity needs.
56. Young people in custody are visited by their PAs, who reflect on what life in prison means for their wellbeing and safety. For some young people in custody, release planning is not specified clearly enough in their pathway plans.
57. Most care leavers live in suitable accommodation. Those living in semi-independent accommodation receive support to develop their independence skills. However, some young people told inspectors that there is more to do to help them prepare for independence.
58. The local offer has been strengthened since the last inspection. It has been co-produced with young people and is regularly reviewed in consultation with them. Most young people are aware of the local authority's offer to care leavers and are accessing elements of it. Each care leaver is provided with a QR code so that they can access the offer easily. The offer includes free travel across Merseyside, priority housing status and leisure centre access. During this inspection, immediate action was taken to extend important elements of the offer up to young people's 25th birthday.
59. Young people told inspectors that it is taking a long time to provide a promised hub and safe space for them to meet. Senior leaders acknowledged the delay and have appropriate plans in place to deliver a hub. Young people are eagerly anticipating its opening to meet more care-experienced young people for mutual support.
60. Participation opportunities for children in care and care leavers in Liverpool are increasing. More young people are getting involved with children in care and care leaver groups and participation initiatives in the corporate parenting arena. Children in care and care leavers told inspectors that they feel listened to and involved in decision-making.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

61. There is now a strong emphasis on securing positive outcomes and safeguarding children in Liverpool. This is driven by a determined and tenacious DCS and her senior leadership team. There is a strong corporate, political and strategic focus on improving services and doing the right thing for children and families. This is underpinned by continued additional financial investment to increase workforce capacity and develop services. The active involvement of the chief executive and council leader in the improvement and corporate parenting boards further supports this.

62. The adoption of a new practice model and revised practice standards is supporting the development of a positive organisational culture, evident across the workforce. Strengthened professional relationships across the partnership are enabling committed leaders to set high expectations of themselves and their staff.
63. Leaders have taken a measured and considered approach to implementing the national reforms, prioritising the development of strong foundations across children's services. Leaders have engaged effectively with partners and national networks to inform and develop local decision-making. This approach has enabled leaders to maintain their focus on sustaining progress without undermining the improvements made to date.
64. Leaders listen to young people. The participation strategy evidences a significant breadth of participation activity across services and forums. The children in care council and care leaver forums are increasingly well attended. The MOMO app has been launched and provides an opportunity for young people's voices to be heard in everyday practice. Leaders are keenly aware that there is more to do to ensure that children's voices are consistently heard and are central to decision- and policy-making.
65. Children are a clear priority for leaders in the local authority. The council is working toward UNICEF child-friendly city accreditation, and all care leavers benefit from protected characteristic status. Corporate parenting duties are embraced and championed. The care leavers' offer, co-produced with children, has been improved. During this inspection, the offer has been enhanced based on feedback provided by inspectors and young people.
66. The commissioning and sufficiency strategy includes an ambitious action plan, which details how leaders intend to meet the diverse sufficiency needs of children in care and care leavers. Actions have included the increase in in-house residential provision, introduction of the first Mockingbird constellation and a bid to deliver a regional care cooperative across Cheshire and Merseyside. Leaders clearly recognise that there is more to do in this space to ensure that all children are able to live in stable homes that meet their needs.
67. Since the inspection in 2023, there have been significant improvements in the quality of core social work practice, including assessments and plans for children. Specialist teams and services have further strengthened the offer to families. These include the development of 12 family hubs, a child exploitation team, and engagement with FDAC. For children who have parents in custody, the local authority Fiona programme delivers an effective trauma-based approach, which has resulted in some children remaining in the care of their families.
68. The DCS and her senior leadership team demonstrate a strong commitment to continuous learning. They proactively pursue opportunities to enhance their knowledge, refine their expertise, and drive sustained improvements in practice.

External scrutiny and challenge from the Department for Education improvement adviser and Liverpool's sector-led improvement partner have been welcomed. Multi-agency work has been prioritised within children's services improvement plans. When shortfalls were identified during this inspection, leaders were able to evidence that decisive action was being taken or already underway to address the issue.

69. The revised quality assurance framework enables senior leaders to maintain a more accurate and meaningful line of sight to frontline practice. There has been a significant cultural shift in how performance data is used, moving beyond compliance monitoring to understanding and improving children's experiences.
70. The response to risk has been strengthened. The more purposeful use of data, tracking systems and panels has reduced drift for most children. Leaders appropriately know there is more to do to ensure sufficient oversight of all children.
71. Leaders have had a significant transformational impact on the workforce culture across children's services. At the time of the last inspection, the workforce was a predominantly temporary staff group. Due to the concerted efforts of the DCS and senior leaders, the majority of staff are now permanent. Many agency workers have converted to permanent roles and many staff who had previously worked for Liverpool children's services have returned. A number of agency project teams that were utilised in the early part of the improvement journey have now ceased.
72. There is now regular management oversight of practice. Managers provide support and guidance to social workers and PAs, and for most children this is resulting in their plans being progressed and them achieving better outcomes.
73. A refreshed workforce strategy and improvement plan are focused on improving practice. A comprehensive training programme is supporting the continuous professional development of staff, and learning circles have been introduced. This enables social workers to build confidence and develop the skills needed to support children effectively.
74. Social workers consistently reported that they feel well supported and appropriately challenged by managers. Workloads have been reduced and most practitioners have the capacity and ability to develop meaningful relationships with children, families and care leavers. Morale is high. Social workers told inspectors that their views matter and that they work in a culture that supports them in their practice. This is a significant improvement since the last inspection.
75. During this inspection, extremely positive feedback was received from the judiciary and the Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service. Significant improvements in practice were described, and trust and confidence in senior leaders' ability to effect change was expressed.

76. Senior leaders describe Liverpool as being on a relentless improvement journey. Their sharp focus on improving outcomes for children has resulted in significant improvements across all service areas. The DCS and her team are acutely aware that the pace of improvement must now be sustained to ensure consistently effective practice for all children and young people in the authority.

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